

Veterans Backbone – Safeguarding Principles Framework

Purpose

Safeguarding is not a department, a form, or a box-ticking exercise.

It is a responsibility shared by everyone connected to Veterans Backbone.

This framework sets out the safeguarding principles that guide decision-making, behaviour, culture, and organisational accountability across all Veterans Backbone activities, services, sites, and partnerships.

Where safeguarding concerns exist, safety takes precedence over convenience, preference, funding, reputation, or operational efficiency.

Core Principle 1 – Safety First

The safety and wellbeing of individuals always takes priority.

Where there is a conflict between safeguarding and any other consideration, safeguarding prevails.

No outcome, programme, activity, relationship, or organisational objective is more important than protecting people from harm.

Core Principle 2 – Dignity & Respect

People are treated as human beings, not problems to be managed.

Safeguarding is carried out in a way that preserves dignity, autonomy, privacy, and respect wherever possible.

Support should never remove a person's humanity.

Core Principle 3 – Adults Remain Adults

Veterans Backbone recognises that adults have the right to make informed decisions, including decisions others may disagree with.

Vulnerability does not remove autonomy.

Safeguarding seeks to protect people from harm, not control their lives.

Core Principle 4 – Human Judgement Matters

Safeguarding decisions are always human-led.

Systems, technology, AI tools, databases, assessments, and frameworks may support decision-making but never replace human judgement.

Responsibility cannot be delegated to software.

Core Principle 5 – Speak Up Early

Concerns should be raised as early as possible.

Individuals are encouraged to report concerns, ask questions, challenge unsafe practices, and seek guidance without fear of blame or retaliation.

Silence is not considered a safeguarding strategy.

Core Principle 6 – Shared Responsibility

Safeguarding belongs to everyone.

Every member of staff, volunteer, trustee, contractor, resident, participant, and partner has a responsibility to contribute to a safe environment.

No individual is expected to carry safeguarding responsibility alone.

Core Principle 7 – Proportionate Response

Actions are based on risk, evidence, context, and professional judgement.

Veterans Backbone avoids both overreaction and inaction.

Responses should be proportionate, reasonable, and focused on reducing harm.

Core Principle 8 – Learning Before Blame

Where safeguarding incidents occur, the priority is learning, improvement, and prevention.

Accountability remains important, but organisational learning is essential.

Mistakes should be examined honestly to strengthen future safeguarding practice.

Core Principle 9 – Safeguarding Overrides Organisational Convenience

Safeguarding concerns are never ignored because they are difficult, uncomfortable, inconvenient, expensive, or politically sensitive.

Protecting people takes precedence over organisational comfort.

Relationship to Other Documents

This framework operates alongside:

- Safeguarding Policy (Adults)
- Incident & Concern Reporting Procedures
- Boundaries & Professional Conduct Policy
- Complaints & Concerns Policy
- Whistleblowing Policy
- Governance & Decision-Making Framework

This document establishes the principles.

Supporting policies and procedures explain how those principles are applied in practice.

Final Statement

Safeguarding is not something Veterans Backbone does.

It is part of who Veterans Backbone is.

Every decision, relationship, activity, and service operates on the understanding that safety, dignity, and wellbeing matter.